

Kane's Late Brace Saves England from Humiliation, But Tuchel's Problems Mount

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England stood 15 minutes from one of the most **abject** humiliations in their World Cup history, until captain Harry Kane delivered a dramatic late **brace** to secure a 2-1 victory over DR Congo and a place in the last 16. The result spared head coach Thomas Tuchel a fate that would have ranked alongside the infamous loss to Iceland at Euro 2016 and the 1950 defeat to the United States. Instead, England now heads to Mexico City to face the co-hosts in the cauldron of Azteca Stadium.

Yet the win papered over cracks that have been evident throughout the tournament. Kane and Jude Bellingham have been England's standout performers, contributing goals and world-class inspiration in group-stage wins over Croatia and Panama, and again against DR Congo. But the **over-reliance** on the duo is glaring. Anthony Gordon made a vital impact off the bench, but Marcus Rashford and Noni Madueke were ineffective, and Bukayo Saka's minutes are being carefully managed due to an Achilles issue. As good as Kane and Bellingham are, there will come a day when they cannot bail out underperforming teammates.

Tuchel's selection decisions have raised eyebrows. The **right-back** position has become a **poisoned chalice**: Tino Livramento didn't even make the squad, Reece James is out with another hamstring injury, Jarell Quansah a natural center-back was tried there but got injured, and Djed Spence lasted 70 minutes against DR Congo before Declan Rice, England's midfield **anchor**, was shifted to **right-back**. The sight of Rice in an unfamiliar role hinted at confusion and a lack of clear planning. Tuchel's constant shuffling on the flanks and in defense suggests he does not know his best team.

Against Mexico, in front of a passionate home crowd, England will need more than individual brilliance. The supporting cast must share the burden, and Tuchel must find defensive stability. Otherwise, the World Cup dream could end in the iconic but intimidating confines of the Azteca.

Word Treasure

brace -- In soccer, scoring two goals in a single match by the same player.

abject -- Describes something extremely bad or disgraceful, used here for a humiliating defeat.

over-reliance -- Depending too much on one or two things, so that the whole group suffers if those things fail.

right-back -- A defensive position on the right side of the soccer field, responsible for stopping attacks and supporting offense.

poisoned chalice -- A phrase meaning a role or task that seems attractive but brings many problems and risks.

anchor -- A player who sits in front of the defense and shields it, often breaking up opponent attacks and linking play; a key defensive midfielder.

Background you need

Thomas Tuchel, the German manager who won the Champions League with Chelsea in 2021, took over as England head coach in October 2024, becoming the team's third foreign-born boss.

Iceland's shock 2-1 victory over England at Euro 2016 is one of the biggest upsets in football history--Iceland's population then was about 330,000, roughly the size of a small English city. In the 1950 World Cup, a group of part-time American players defeated a heavily favored England 1-0 in Brazil, a result still remembered as a massive humiliation.

Azteca Stadium, located at 2,200 meters above sea level, is famous for its thin air, which leaves visiting players gasping, and has hosted two World Cup finals (1970 and 1986).

Harry Kane broke Wayne Rooney's record in 2023 to become England's all-time leading goalscorer, while Jude Bellingham, still only 21, was one of the brightest talents at the 2022 World Cup.

Break it down

LEAD: Harry Kane's dramatic late brace rescues England from 15 minutes from humiliation
 +- HISTORICAL COMPARISON: loss nearly as bad as Iceland 2016 and 1950 USA defeat

CRACKS PAPERED OVER: win hides deeper problems

+- OVER-RELIANCE: Kane and Bellingham carried team, others ineffective

+- SUPPORTING CAST: Gordon impact from bench, Rashford/Madueke ineffective, Saka injury-managed

+- WARNING: duo will not always bail out teammates

COACHING CONCERNS: Tuchel's selection problems exposed

+- RIGHT-BACK POISONED CHALICE: Livramento out, James injured, Quansah injured, Spence subbed

+- CONFUSION: midfielder Declan Rice shifted to right-back, suggesting lack of planning

LOOKING AHEAD: next match vs Mexico at intimidating Azteca Stadium

OPEN QUESTION: Can England find defensive stability and share the burden before knockout pressure hits?

Why it matters

The match reveals an England team still too dependent on individual stars, a pattern that has caused repeated tournament failures. Facing a passionate host nation in Mexico's high-altitude stadium, these unresolved selection flaws could end their World Cup dream--or push them to finally find a balanced team.

Test what you remember

1. Who scored both goals in England's 2-1 win over DR Congo?
 - (A) Jude Bellingham
 - (B) Marcus Rashford
 - (C) Harry Kane
 - (D) Declan Rice
2. Which opponent did England defeat to reach the last 16?
 - (A) Croatia
 - (B) Panama
 - (C) DR Congo
 - (D) Mexico
3. Which past England humiliation is mentioned alongside the potential loss to DR Congo?
 - (A) Losing to Iceland at Euro 2016 and the 1950 defeat to the United States
 - (B) Losing to Argentina in 1986
 - (C) Failing to qualify for 1994 World Cup
 - (D) Loss to Germany in 2010
4. Which two players are called England's standout performers throughout the tournament?
 - (A) Marcus Rashford and Bukayo Saka
 - (B) Harry Kane and Jude Bellingham
 - (C) Declan Rice and Anthony Gordon
 - (D) Reece James and Harry Kane
5. After Djed Spence was substituted, which player was moved to right-back?
 - (A) Jude Bellingham
 - (B) Noni Madueke
 - (C) Declan Rice
 - (D) Tino Livramento
6. Where will England play their next match?
 - (A) Wembley Stadium, London
 - (B) Azteca Stadium, Mexico City
 - (C) MetLife Stadium, New Jersey
 - (D) Rose Bowl, Los Angeles

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive:** Harry Kane's late goals and Jude Bellingham's creativity give England a chance to win even on poor days. Captain Kane's leadership under pressure shows the team has a fighter's spirit that can carry them deep into the tournament.
- 2. Negative / Critical:** Coach Thomas Tuchel has no settled right-back and is constantly shuffling the defense, suggesting poor preparation. The over-reliance on two stars means a single off-day or injury could send England crashing out against stronger opponents.
- 3. Neutral / Analytical:** England's historical pattern of relying on a few key talents rather than a cohesive system has often been their undoing in major tournaments. The current squad depth is great on paper, but integrating new players into a clear tactical setup remains a puzzle.
- 4. Forward-looking:** The match against Mexico in the Azteca will test not only the players' fitness at altitude but also Tuchel's ability to field a balanced side. If the supporting cast does not step up and the defense is not settled, the tournament could end abruptly, raising bigger questions about England's long-term direction.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):